



FATEMEH BAHRAMI Anadolu

POSSIBLE U.S. WAR CRIMES IN IRAN

Families visit a school — now a cemetery — in Minab, Iran, that was struck by a missile in February. A U.N. panel found “reasonable grounds” to fault two American strikes in the Islamic Republic. **WORLD, A2**

State’s insurers can’t use marital status

In a reversal for auto rates, commissioner says unmarried drivers should not pay more.

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

For decades, single, divorced and many widowed drivers have paid more for auto insurance in California than those who are married. That could soon change. Insurance Commissioner Ricardo Lara, in a surprising decision, announced Wednesday that he is barring auto insurers from considering marital status in setting premiums.

While the insurance department has previously defended the regulation as valid because unmarried drivers are more prone to get into accidents than married ones, it cast doubt on that position in a regulatory filing last week.

The department said that while there is a correlation between marital status and accident rates, the correlation could be driven by secondary factors, such as income, educational attainment and employment.

“In light of evolving societal norms, the Commissioner deems there is insufficient justification for the continued use of marital status in automobile insurance rating,” the filing stated.

The change must go through a review to ensure it adheres to state law before it can take effect.

California would join a handful of states, including Massachusetts and Hawaii, that bar the use of marital status in setting auto insurance rates.

Unmarried drivers would see discounts in the future when insurers seek approval for new rate plans from the department.

The department will no longer allow marital status to be used for any rate plan filed after Oct. 25 under the proposed rule change, and insurers must file new plans eliminating marital status as a rating factor by July 1, 2027.

The regulatory change was included in a legal brief filed by the department in a lawsuit brought by 11 unmarried drivers seeking to overturn the policy.

A state appellate panel decision upholding the marital status policy is being appealed to the state Supreme Court.

A test conducted by the Consumer Federation of America, cited in a legal brief [See Insurance, A12]

Snow, not rain, drives groundwater recharge

Gradual mountain melt seeps to aquifers; liquid precipitation, not so much, satellite data confirm

By Ian James

For the first time, scientists have found a direct link between the snow that falls on California’s mountains and the groundwater that lies beneath Central Valley farmlands.

Analyzing two decades of measurements from NASA satellites, the researchers discovered that after a snowy winter in the Sierra Nevada, the melting snow that runs off the mountains substantially raises water levels underground.

The study documents just how important years of heavy snow are for recharging California’s groundwater aquifers. It also reveals that a year with rain but little snow doesn’t benefit the state’s underground water nearly as much.

“It really does seem that the snow, rather than the rain, is what drives the groundwater recharge,” said J.T. Reager, the study’s lead author. “If it rains, a lot of that rain is going to run right off, whereas if it snows, that snow sits there and slowly melts over the entire spring and summer, and provides this nice steady, infiltrating trickle that provides water to farmers, puts more water in reservoirs and also recharges the ground.”

In the Central Valley, groundwater has been dropping for decades as wells and pumps pull up water to irrigate crops. Scientists estimate that since the early 20th century, the Central Valley has lost more groundwater than the total volume of Lake Tahoe. [See Water, A8]

AI fears heighten the stakes of Xi’s Washington visit

Chance for a deal to guard against runaway technology low given U.S., China distrust.

By MICHAEL WILNER AND NILESH CHRISTOPHER

WASHINGTON — A growing sense of urgency over the risks posed by artificial intelligence is adding pressure on the Trump administration to secure a diplomatic breakthrough with China when Chinese President Xi Jinping travels to the White House for a state visit next week.

Expectations for a deal that establishes guardrails on AI are low on both sides, which continue to drive a headlong race toward potentially unfathomable intelligence capabilities. Ahead of the meeting, rhetoric from Washington and Beijing has underscored only deepening acrimony and distrust over their rush to dominate the technological frontier.

But an article published this week by Beijing’s spy chief, warning that runaway AI capabilities could threaten Communist Party con-

trol, caught the attention of the Trump administration. One U.S. official told The Times that the blunt assessment accurately reflects private thinking inside Xi’s government about the growing risks.

Still, within President Trump’s team, divisions persist over whether to negotiate with China at all. Top U.S. officials doubt whether any agreement could be credibly enforced or verified. Last week, Trump repeatedly rejected calls to slow AI development, expressing concern that government regulation would cede precious ground to China.

And a high-profile U.S. debate over AI safety, kicked off last week by a warning from an AI researcher, prompted a defensive response from Beijing, where a Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson accused Washington of “farmongering, confrontation and vicious competition.”

The U.S. approach “will only disrupt the process of global AI governance,” the ministry said, “which serves no one’s interests.”

Some American AI companies — led by Anthropic and OpenAI, the most ad-

[See Summit, A12]



JACQUELYN MARTIN Associated Press

THE U.S. Marine Band rehearses at the White House for Chinese leader Xi Jinping’s visit next week.

UC checks answer on dropping SAT

Discussion opens on reinstating testing as math grades fall but degree rates are stable.

By JAWEED KALEEM

The University of California regents opened their first sustained public discussion Wednesday about whether to reinstate the SAT requirement in admissions, as math grades continue to slide, dueling opinions surfaced, and one regent who voted to eliminate

the exam said he was starting to think his decision may have been “a mistake.”

Regents heard that math performance is the exception to otherwise strong academic results among first-year students. Average grades in preparatory math, precalculus and calculus across UC continue their five-year decline, while D and F grades, no-pass marks and withdrawals in those courses have gone up.

But most UC freshmen never take the courses. Among students who entered in fall 2023, 31% took preparatory math, precalcu-

lus or first-year calculus in their first two years, while 41% started in a more advanced course, according to data presented by the UC Office of the President. Together, the introductory courses make up about 5% of the classes freshmen take, ranging from 2% at UC Irvine to 12% at UC Merced.

Yet earlier in the day, UCLA and UC Riverside admissions officials told the 26-member board they have found no evidence that students admitted without test scores are less likely to stay in school or graduate.

Regent Lark Park said

the data, overall, settle little. “Some of the data lead me to think we do have a math problem, but I don’t exactly know what it is,” she said.

Pressure on the regents to quickly decide on the future of the SAT has grown since early this summer. More than 3,000 UC faculty members, from all nine undergraduate campuses, have signed two letters demanding the SAT’s return. They said first-year students are at times arriving in classrooms lacking basic math and reasoning skills and that they have often re-

[See UC, A7]

Vintage rides get a smog test pass

Enthusiast Jay Leno pushed to relax emissions rules for more collector cars.

By CLARA HARTER

Whether it’s a sleek, low-slung Impala, a candy apple red Monte Carlo or a roaring T-top Trans Am — the classic cars of the late 1970s and the ’80s are an iconic part of California’s automotive heritage.

But many of these vehicles have been relegated to driveways and garages due to the challenge of passing a smog check. Auto lovers have pushed for years to lessen emissions regulations for collector cars, arguing that these vintage vehicles are driven only short distances to parades and meetups where they deserve to be cherished.

Enthusiasts found a powerful champion in famed comedian and auto aficionado Jay Leno, who boasts more than 150 vehicles in his personal collection.

On Wednesday, he secured a big win for the classic car community when Gov. Gavin Newsom paid a visit to his Burbank garage to sign Senate Bill 1392, also known as Jay Leno’s Law, legislation that expands smog check exemptions for certain collector cars.

Over the next few years, the law will phase in smog check exemptions for collector cars built from model years 1976 through 1985 that are not used as a primary [See Smog checks, A8]

A big California Latino gender gap

UCLA study finds more young Latina voters against Trump’s agenda than Latinos.

By CLARA HARTER

Young and working-class Latina voters in California care more about protecting immigrant communities and fighting President Trump’s agenda than their male counterparts, according to a UCLA study.

The findings from researchers at the university’s Latino Policy and Politics Institute illustrate how gender can correlate with differences in policy views among California Latinos, who account for about a third of the state’s eligible voters.

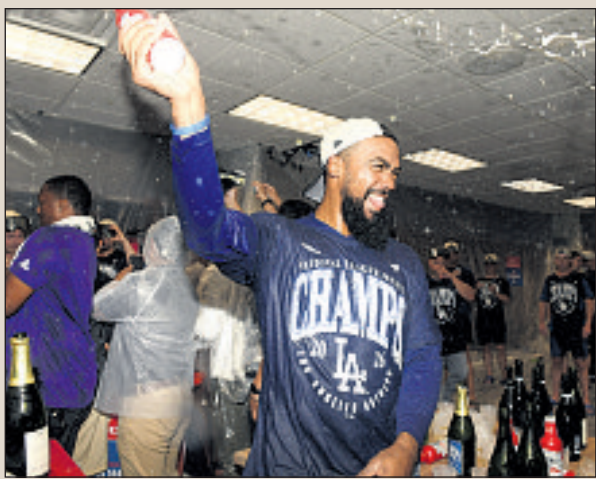
Study co-author G. Cristina Mora noted that while the Latino population tends to vote Democratic overall, the community is far from a monolith and there are valuable insights to be

gleaned from analyzing the difference in policy views among population subgroups.

This is especially important considering that the Latino population has the largest gap between eligible voters and actual voters among any racial or ethnic group in California, she added.

“If I were working for an immigration rights group, or something like that, I’d be thinking, ‘I really need to get the working-class Latina voters up to the polls,’” said Mora, a co-director of the Institute of Governmental Studies at UC Berkeley. “‘I really need to reach them,’ is what this sort of report would imply to me.”

The study, based on a May UC Berkeley IGS poll of 1,912 Latino registered voters in California, found that Latinas under 30 tend to hold more progressive views on topics such as immigration, voting rights and opposing Trump than Latino [See Latinos, A7]



TANNER PEARSON Associated Press

SUDS WITH THE BUDS

Teoscar Hernández celebrates with beer in the clubhouse after the Dodgers clinched the NL West on Thursday in Cincinnati. **SPORTS, B10**

No ICE arrests without warrant

An L.A. federal judge orders SoCal agents to determine whether a person is likely to escape. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 82/65. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Warehouse firm denies blame

Lineage says it didn’t cause Boyle Heights fire and did a lot to help neighbors. **BUSINESS, A9**

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